

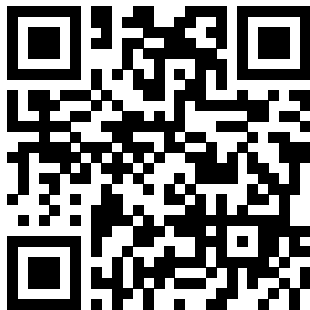
From SNNs to Silicon: Compiling FPGA Bitstreams from Spiking Neural Networks

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Note: You can find up-to-date slides using the following link



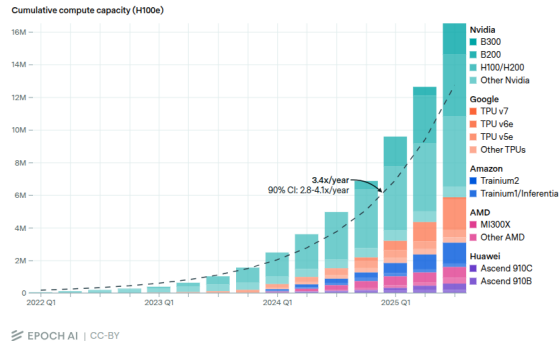
<https://neuralfpga.github.io/26iscas/>

Why this tutorial?

- ▶ **Neuromorphic computing** is a potential solution the scalability issues of neural network-based AI.
- ▶ The current *bottleneck* for large-scale neuromorphic computing is **co-design**^a.
- ▶ We would like to demonstrate our framework **NIR2FPGA**, an *end-to-end design flow* for
 1. Simulating,
 2. Quantizing,
 3. and CompilingRTL from neuromorphic algorithms.

^aDhiresha Kudithipudi et al. 'Neuromorphic computing at scale'. In: *Nature* 637.8047 (2025), pp. 801–812

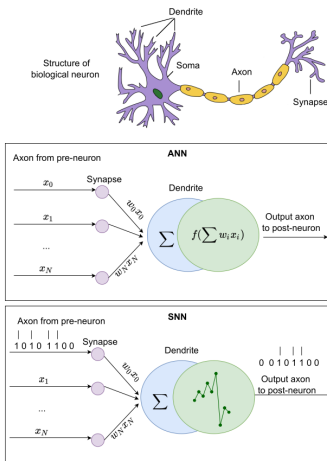
The total computing power of the stock of AI chips is growing at a rate of 3.4×/year.



Source: Sevilla et al., "Compute Trends Across Three Eras of Machine Learning," Epoch AI, 2022. CC BY 4.0.

What is Neuromorphic Computing?

- ▶ **Neuromorphic Computing:** Exploring parallels between biological neurons and neural computation.
- ▶ **Spiking Neural Networks (SNNs):** Neural networks with time domain and more *realistic neuron models*.
- ▶ **Differences** compared to Artificial NNs:
 - ▶ *Sparsity:* Typical ANNs such as AlexNet or VGG models exhibit 60-70% activation sparsity. SNNs can get up to 99%.
 - ▶ *Localised Learning:* Time domain enables novel bio-inspired, robust learning algorithms.
 - ▶ *Energy Efficiency:* Event-driven, sparse computation translates to orders-of-magnitude lower power on neuromorphic hardware [2].



Biological neuron vs Artificial Neural Network (ANN) vs Spiking Neural Network (SNN) (as in [2])

Who are we?



**Michail
Rontionov**

Univ. of Southampton

- ▶ PhD Student supervised by **David Thomas**
- ▶ FPGAs, compilers, languages.
- ▶ Tutorial Lead



**Jens E.
Pedersen**

DTU

- ▶ Postdoctorate
- ▶ Author of Norse and NIR
- ▶ Head of Open Neuromorphic



**Charlotte
Frenkel**

TU Delft

- ▶ Assistant Professor Delft
- ▶ Research Scientist @ Google
- ▶ ODIN & ReckOn Online Learning Chips



**Francisco Ayala
Le Brun**

TU Delft

- ▶ Bullet 1
- ▶ Bullet 2
- ▶ Bullet 3



Nassim Beladel

ETH Zurich

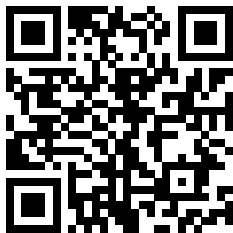
- ▶ Msc Student EEIT
- ▶ Chair of the Young Neuromorphics
- ▶

Schedule

Time	Topic	Presenters
08:30	Welcome	Michail Rontionov
08:40	Neuromorphic Engineering and Design Approaches	Charlotte Frenkel
09:00	Neuromorphic FPGA Design Paradigms	Nassim Beladel
09:15	Neuromorphic Intermediate Representation (NIR)	Jens E. Pedersen
09:30	Hands-on: Defining, Training & Exporting SNNs	Jens E. Pedersen & Michail Rontionov
10:00	<i>Coffee Break</i>	
10:15	NIR2FPGA	Michail Rontionov
10:30	SpinalHDL Introduction	Francisco Ayala Le Brun
10:45	Hands-on: • <i>Livecode:</i> using NIR2FPGA to develop SNN RTL. • <i>Exercise:</i> Defining a LIF neuron in SpinalHDL. • <i>Exercise:</i> Evaluating an RTL MNIST SNN.	Michail Rontionov
11:45	Thank you, and goodbye!	All

Hands-on Preparation

- ▶ Our hands-on exercises assumes an *account on GitHub.com*, **or** *vscode* with WSL and docker.
- ▶ Please go to the link



`github.com/mrontio/nir2fpga-iscas`

Code → Codespaces →
Create codespace on main.

